CHAPTER 7

CROSSROADS

It wasn't going to be enough.

It simply wasn't going to be enough for me to play cricket for South Africa and to play a big innings now and then and then to endure some poor form and then to make some runs again. It wasn't going to be enough for me to be just another run-of-the-mill international batsman with an average in the mid-30s.

I wanted to be much better than that. I didn't say anything to anyone – there was no point boasting or bragging. But, quietly and privately, I promised myself I would become the best batsman in the world. That was my goal. Nothing less would suffice. I believed I had the potential, and I wanted to be No. 1.

And yet, as the 2007 season unfolded, it started to become clear that significant changes would need to be made in two specific areas if there was to be any chance of this goal being realised.

First, I needed to improve my batting technique, specifically to develop a correct and solid defence. Just playing strokes and attacking almost every delivery was not going to be enough.

Second, I needed to become much more disciplined, more organised and more professional, on and off the field; I needed to create a trusted support system that would enable me to focus exclusively on the cricket. Living from match to match, from deal to deal, from party to party